relatively minor 'border incidents'; it was inadequate for dealing with anything larger than that.

Beyond the stopping power of the Himalaya, the basic Indian calculation was that the 'correlation of forces' – the balance of power – would deter China: Soviet, US, and British power plus global opinion would hold back Beijing's hand. In Nehru's view, Beijing would be aware that the US and Soviets might become involved in a wider war: 'the Chinese are unlikely to invade India because they know that this would start a world war, which the Chinese cannot want'.[81] Nehru also thought that Moscow would restrain Beijing due to its own growing rivalry with China.[82] Delhi's view of the correlation of forces turned out to be wrong. India forgot that China had demonstrated an ability to take calculated risks and to defy both the US and Soviets. In 1950, only a year after the communists had seized power in the mainland, they had launched a massive military attack against the US-led UN forces in Korea, fought them at hight cost for three years, and pushed them back down the peninsula. In 1954–55, mainland China had shelled Taiwan despite the risk that Washington would get involved. In the 1950s, India was also among the first to sense that China was standing up to the Soviets ideologically and diplomatically within the global communist movement. Clearly, then, China was far more 'risk-acceptant' than India estimated.

India's confidence that China would avoid a full-scale war was broadcast publicly and underlined by the casual stance of the leadership in the months and weeks leading up to hostilities. For instance, on 5 December 1961, in Parliament Nehru discounted the possibility of war with China.[83] More than Indian statements, though, were the actions of its leadership, in the closing days before the fight. On 17 September 1962, Defence Minister Krishna Menon left for a UN meeting and only returned on 30 September. Nehru went to the Commonwealth meeting in London as well as to Paris, Lagos, and Accra on 8 September and returned only on 2 October. He then left India again, to visit Ceylon on 12 October and returned on 16 October, four days before China attacked. General Kaul, Chief of the General Staff, was